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Off-shore RMB bond market

CNH Credit Reimagined II: The Rise of a Strategic Funding Market

Industry Overview

CNH Bond Market Has Entered a New Phase

Issuance reached RMB704bn in the first nine months of 2026, up 59% YoY, while outstanding bonds increased 23% from end-2025 to RMB1.9tn (US$284bn), equivalent to around 70% of China's offshore USD bond market. Importantly, growth has been accompanied by a broader investor and issuer base and a meaningful extension in duration: nearly 30% of YTD issuance has an average life of more than seven years, including 16% in the 10-20 year bucket. The increase in scale and availability of long-dated funding suggest to us that CNH is evolving from a niche, predominantly short-dated market into a deeper and increasingly strategic offshore funding channel.

Investor Access Is the New Funding Advantage

The rise of offshore Chinese capital has fundamentally changed the rationale for CNH issuance. Even as the funding advantage versus USD has largely disappeared, Per Bloomberg data, CNH issuance rose 59% YoY to RMB704bn in the first nine months of 2026, led by foreign banks, while Mainland Southbound holdings increased sharply. A broader institutional investor base, growing offshore RMB liquidity and the yield and diversification benefits of CNH bonds are creating a deeper pool of Chinese capital for issuers to access, in our view. CNH is increasingly becoming an investor-access market rather than one driven primarily by funding costs.

Global Banks and China Tech Reshape the Issuer Base

The CNH issuer base is undergoing a structural shift. U.S. GSIB issuance has surged to US$22bn YTD, making CNH their third-largest funding currency after USD and EUR, while Chinese internet companies have raised RMB57bn, bringing CNH issuance broadly in line with their USD bond issuance, per Bloomberg data. We would expect both groups to remain strategic users of the market driven by access to Chinese capital and, for internet companies, growing AI-related funding needs. In contrast, LGFV issuance has fallen from its RMB190bn peak in 2024 to below RMB79bn YTD and should decline further as offshore borrowing remains tightly controlled and largely restricted to refinancing.

Strong Demand, Policy Sets the Growth Pace

The previous RMB500bn Southbound quota was almost fully utilized within a year, supported by CNH bonds' higher yields and broader diversification versus onshore alternatives. The increase to RMB800bn provides substantial room for further growth and, relative to the current RMB1.9tn market, represents potential annual inflows equivalent to more than 40% of existing market size. We see scope for Chinese technology companies and U.S. GSIBs to remain strategic issuers, with more investment-grade corporates, financial institutions, sovereigns and supranationals potentially tapping the market. With underlying demand remaining strong, policy capacity is likely to become an increasingly important determinant of how quickly the market can expand.

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Refer to important disclosures on page 15 to 17. 13030242

21 October 2026

Global Corporate Credit
Asia

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Joyce Liang
Research Analyst
Merrill Lynch (Singapore)
+65 6678 0408
joyce.liang@bofa.com

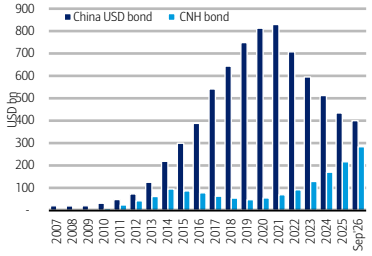
Di Miao, CFA
Research Analyst
Merrill Lynch (Hong Kong)
dmiao@bofa.com

Asia Pacific Credit Rsch Grp
Merrill Lynch (Singapore)

See Team Page for List of Analysts

Exhibit 1: Outstanding of China USD bond and CNH bond

Size of China USD bond peaked in 2021, dropped to US$400bn the latest; meanwhile, size of CNH bond grew to US$284bn, more than quadrupled the size in 2021



Source: Bloomberg, Dealogic, BofA Global Research
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See link to report below:

Asian Credit Strategy: CNH Credit Reimagined: A Primer on the Dim Sum Bond Market's Resurgence 31 October 2025

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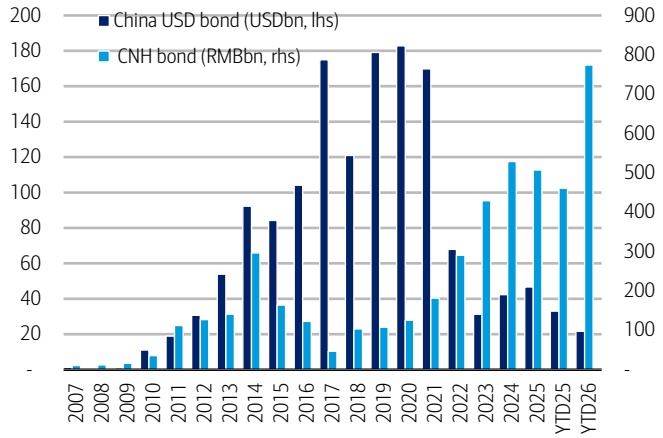
CNH Bond Mkt Has Entered a New Phase

The CNH bond market is entering a new phase of development, characterized by rapid growth in market size, a broader investor base, a more diversified issuer universe and a meaningful extension in duration. Since end-2021, the market has evolved from a niche funding venue into a strategically important component of China's offshore capital markets.

Issuance reached RMB704bn in the first nine months of 2026, up 59% YoY, while total outstanding bonds grew 23% from end-2025 to RMB1.9tn (US$284bn). The market is now equivalent to around 70% of China's offshore USD bond market, compared with less than half just two years ago.

More importantly, the growth trajectory of the CNH market has diverged sharply from that of the offshore USD bond market. Since peaking in 2021, China's offshore USD bond market has contracted significantly, weighed down by the collapse in property-sector issuance, deleveraging by Chinese corporates and reduced demand for USD funding. In contrast, the CNH market has nearly quadrupled in size since end-2021. As a result, the gap between the two markets has narrowed rapidly. What was once viewed as a complementary funding market is increasingly emerging as a core offshore financing channel in its own right.

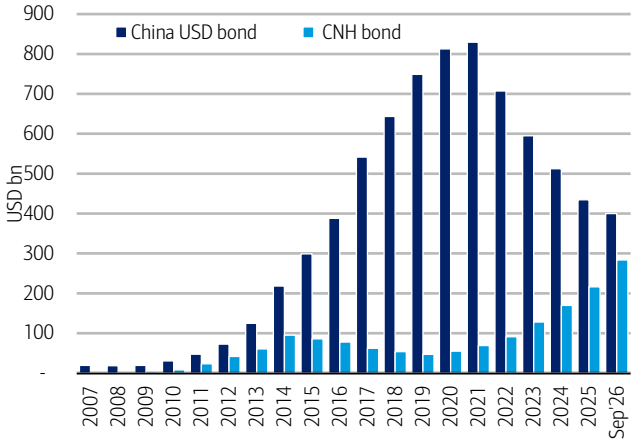
Exhibit 2: CNH bond issuance vs. China USD bond issuance
China USD bond issuance has declined since 2022, vs. rising CNH bond issuance



Source: Bloomberg, BofA Global Research
Note: YTD26 as of Oct 20 2026

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Exhibit 3: Outstanding of China USD bond and CNH bond
Size of China USD bond peaked in 2021, dropped to US$400bn the latest; meanwhile, size of CNH bond grew to US$284bn, more than quadrupled the size in 2021



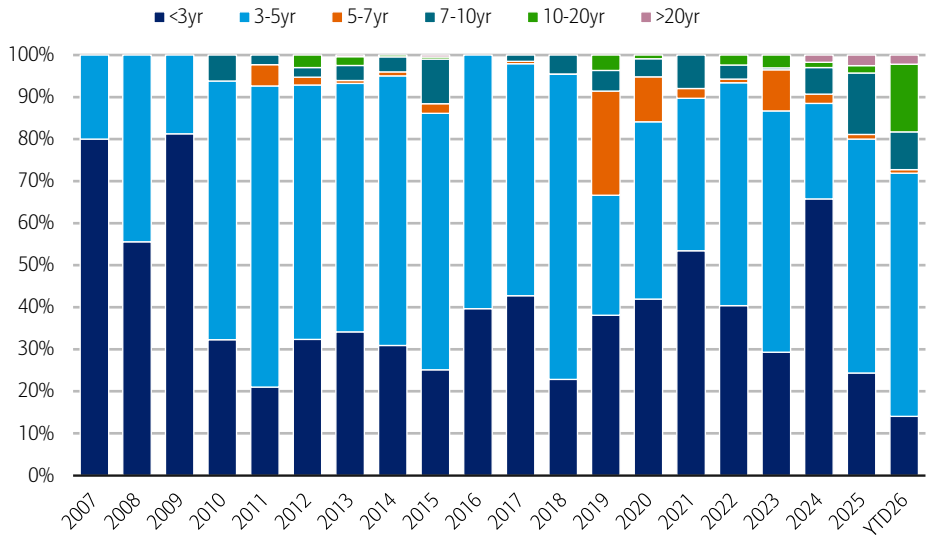
Source: Bloomberg, Dealogic, BofA Global Research

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The market has also deepened materially. Historically, CNH issuance was dominated by short-dated bonds, reflecting a relatively narrow investor base and limited demand for duration. This is gradually changing. Nearly 30% of issuance year-to-date has an average life of more than seven years, including 16% in the 10-20 year tenor bucket. The increasing ability of issuers to access long-dated funding suggests that the market is evolving beyond a tactical funding venue and is becoming capable of supporting strategic funding needs.

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Exhibit 4: Breakdown of CNH bond issuance tenor since 2007
The CNH bond tenor has been increasing in 2025/YTD26



Source: Bloomberg, BofA Global Research
Note: YTD26 as of Oct 20 2026

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A key differentiator from previous growth cycles is the expansion of the investor base. Historically, demand was concentrated among offshore RMB investors and Chinese banks. Regulatory reforms have since broadened market access to include onshore insurers, asset managers, securities firms and wealth-management institutions. The rapid growth in Southbound Bond Connect participation suggests that Mainland institutional capital is becoming an increasingly important driver of market demand.

The role of the market has also evolved. During its early years, CNH issuance was primarily driven by RMB tion and funding-cost considerations. Today, the market is serving two increasingly important functions. For Chinese corporates, particularly technology companies, it has become an important offshore funding channel for refinancing, overseas investment and capital management activities. For foreign issuers, the market is increasingly viewed as a means of accessing China's growing offshore capital pool. The rapid increase in issuance by global financial institutions, especially U.S. banks, illustrates this shift.

We expect strong market growth to continue, although the pace will increasingly depend on policy quotas. Following the expansion of the Southbound Bond Connect investor base in July 2025, bonds held through Shanghai Clearing House increased by RMB460bn to RMB1.0tn as of end-August 2026, close to the previous RMB500bn annual investment quota. The increase in the annual quota to RMB800bn provides significant additional capacity for Mainland inflows. Relative to the current RMB1.9tn CNH market, the new annual quota is equivalent to more than 40% of existing market size, leaving substantial room for further growth.

Strong underlying demand and an already sizeable market should, in turn, attract more supply. We expect CNH to remain a strategic funding source for Chinese technology companies and U.S. GSIBs, while the expanding investor base should encourage more high-quality investment-grade issuers across sectors and countries to tap the market. With investor demand remaining strong, we see the Southbound quota as an increasingly important constraint on how quickly the market can expand: further policy relaxation could accelerate growth, while an unchanged quota could moderate the pace.

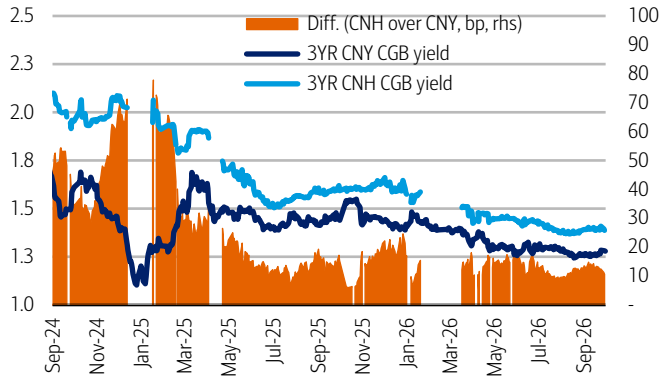
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From Cost Advantage to Investor Access

Historically, the growth of the CNH market was closely linked to funding-cost advantages. Foreign issuers could often achieve lower all-in borrowing costs by issuing CNH bonds and swapping the proceeds back into USD. However, this dynamic has largely disappeared.

As foreign issuers increasingly swapped CNH proceeds back into USD, the resulting receiving of CNH and paying of USD in the cross-currency swap market compressed much of the funding arbitrage. Today, hedged CNH funding costs are broadly comparable to USD funding costs. As of end-Sep'26, hedged 3-year CNH government bond yields were only around 10bp inside comparable U.S. Treasuries, while 10-year and 20-year CNH yields provided approximately 20bp and 60bp pick-up, respectively. The narrowing funding differential suggests that cost savings are no longer the primary driver of CNH issuance.

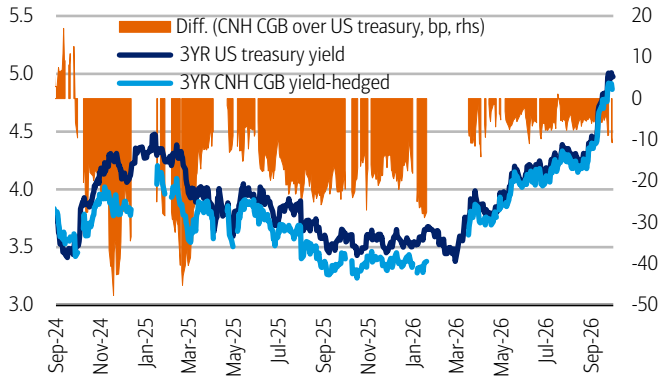
Exhibit 5: 3-year China government bond, CNH vs CNY
CNH yield is higher than CNY yield in the past two years; the current differential is 10bps as end-Sep'26 (vs. 20bps as end-2025)



Source: Bloomberg, BofA Global Research

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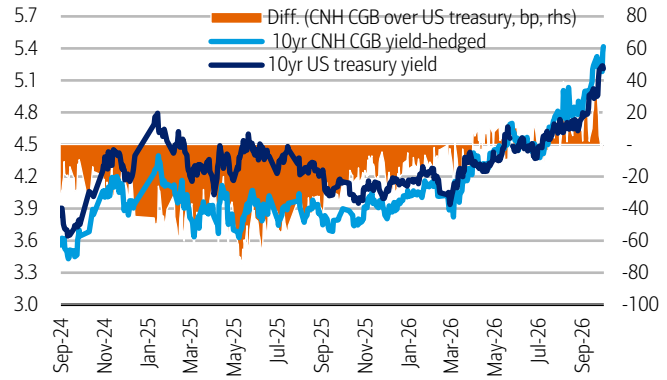
Exhibit 6: 3-year US treasury yield vs 3-year CNH CGB yield-hedged
On hedged basis, 3yr CNH CGB yield is lower than 3yr US treasury in the past two years; the differential is 10bps as end-Sep'26 (vs. 20bps as end-2025)



Source: Bloomberg, BofA Global Research

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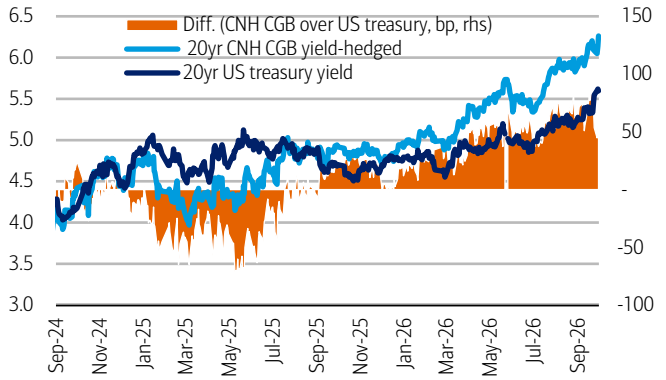
Exhibit 7: 10-year US treasury yield vs 10-year CNH CGB yield-hedged
On hedged basis, 10yr CNH CGB yield now provides around 20bp pick-up over US treasury



Source: Bloomberg, BofA Global Research

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Exhibit 8: 20-year US treasury yield vs 20-year CNH CGB yield-hedged
On hedged basis, 20yr CNH CGB yield now provides 60bp pick-up over US treasury



Source: Bloomberg, BofA Global Research

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Robust year-to-date issuance, led by foreign banks

Yet issuance has continued to accelerate. CNH bond issuance reached RMB774bn in YTD 2026, up 68% YoY, despite the diminishing funding advantage. The growth was broad-

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based but led overwhelmingly by financial institutions, whose issuance increased 139% YoY and accounted for 57% of total supply.

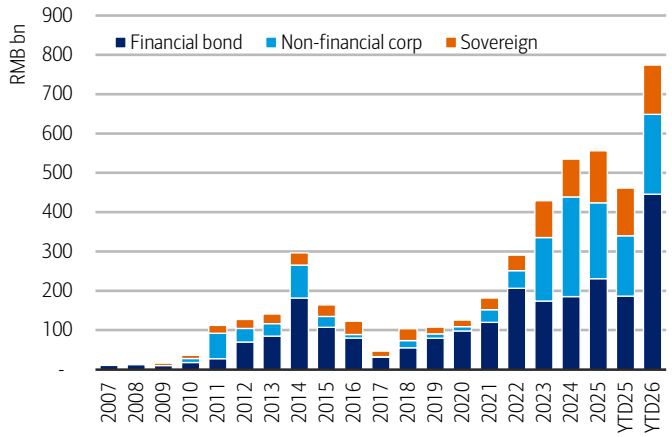
Per Bloomberg data, foreign financial institutions have been the largest contributors to market growth. YTD issuance reached RMB333bn, up RMB209bn, or 169% YoY, and already exceeds twice the average annual issuance recorded during 2022-25. The increase was driven primarily by U.S. banks, whose issuance rose to RMB167bn, up RMB130bn from a year earlier.

The shift is particularly notable given the traditional funding behaviour of U.S. GSIBs. Historically, they relied overwhelmingly on USD markets and only began diversifying meaningfully into EUR funding following the Fed hiking cycle. The sharp increase in CNH issuance despite limited funding-cost advantages suggests that access to a growing offshore RMB investor base has become an increasingly important consideration.

Outside the financial sector, issuance trends further highlight the changing issuer mix. LGFV issuance declined 6% YoY to RMB79bn and is now less than half its 2024 peak, reflecting reduced funding needs amid ongoing deleveraging efforts. By contrast, non-LGFV corporate issuance increased 77% YoY to RMB124bn, of which 44% were issued by Chinese technology firms. Foreign corporate participation remains limited, with less than RMB12bn of issuance year to date.

Taken together, recent issuance patterns suggest that the CNH market is evolving beyond its original role as a funding-cost advantage venue. Growth is increasingly driven by issuers seeking access to offshore Chinese capital, while the rapid expansion of issuance from foreign banks points to the emergence of CNH as a strategically relevant funding market rather than a purely opportunistic one.

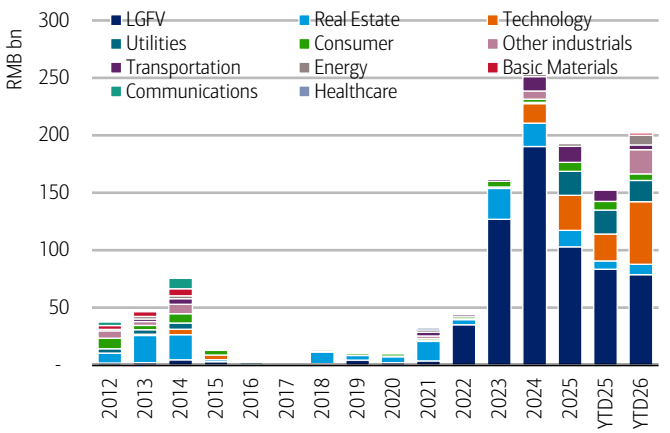
Exhibit 9: CNH bond issuance trend, in RMB bn, since 2007
CNH bond issuance has significantly increased since 2022 driven by 1) cheaper CNH funding vs. USD, 2) issuance from China LGFVs due to tightened onshore funding, 3) growing demand for RMB assets; YTD26 issuance reached RMB774bn, +68% YoY, led by strong global bank issuance



Source: Bloomberg, BofA Global Research
Note: YTD26 as of Oct 20 2026

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Exhibit 10: CNH non-financial corp bond issuance trend since 2012, in RMB bn
The CNH non-financial corp bond issuance was muted during 2015-20; China LGFV is the major driver since 2022; however, the share of China LGFV declined to 53% in 2025 and further to 40% in YTD26; meanwhile, more issuance came from tech, utility, industrial companies



Source: Bloomberg, BofA Global Research
Note: YTD26 as of Oct 20 2026

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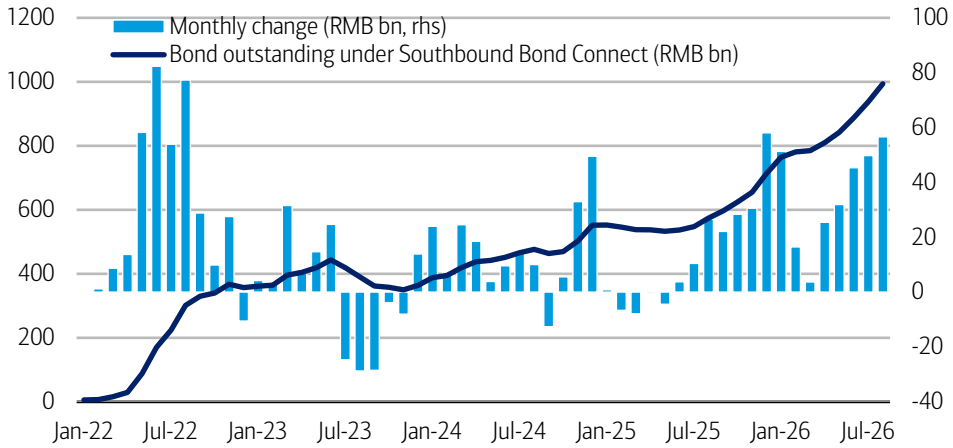
The Rise of Offshore Chinese Capital

The rapid growth of the CNH market has been accompanied by a sharp increase in Mainland participation. Following the expansion of the eligible investor base in July 2025, bonds held through Southbound Bond Connect reached RMB1.0tn as of end-August 2026, according to Shanghai Clearing House, representing an 85% increase over the past year, or an increase of RMB460bn, which is close to the annual investment

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quota of RMB500bn before the recent revision. Actual Mainland holdings are likely even higher, as some investors hold offshore bonds through onshore settlement and custody banks rather than through Bond Connect channels.

Exhibit 11: Bond held by Shanghai Clearing House under the Southbound Bond Connect Program
As of end-Aug'26, bond outstanding held by SHCH under the Southbound Bond Connect Program reached RMB1.0tn, increasing RMB460bn post eligible investor expansion (Jul'25)



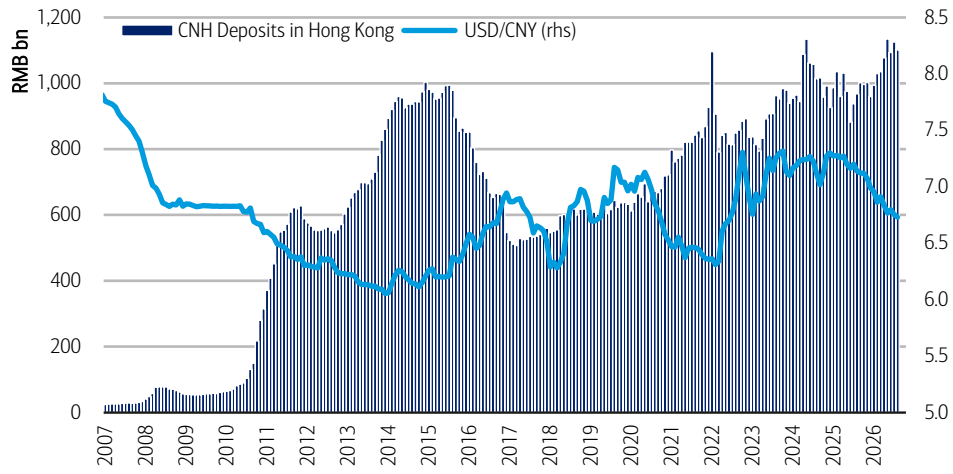
Source: Shanghai Clearing House, Bloomberg

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We believe the expansion of offshore Chinese capital is being driven by three factors: improving RMB stability, continued policy support and the increasingly attractive risk-return profile of offshore credit relative to onshore alternatives.

First, a more stable RMB has supported the recovery of offshore RMB liquidity. Following several years of depreciation pressure, exchange-rate expectations have become more balanced, reducing the incentive to move capital out of RMB and supporting growth in CNH deposits. The resulting increase in offshore RMB liquidity provides a larger pool of capital available for deployment into CNH fixed-income assets.

Exhibit 12: CNH deposit in Hong Kong
Strong correlation between CNH deposit level and FX (USD/CNY); CNH deposit grows when RMB appreciate; CNH deposit reached RMB1.1trn as end of Aug'26, up 15% from end-2025 (RMB appreciated 3.8% in the period)



Source: HKMA, BofA Global Research

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Second, regulatory relaxation has meaningfully expanded the potential investor base. Over the past two years, authorities have progressively relaxed access to offshore RMB markets by broadening Southbound Bond Connect participation and increasing

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investment quotas. Importantly, capital inflows are no longer driven solely by banks. Insurers, fund managers, securities firms and wealth-management institutions are becoming increasingly important participants, resulting in a larger and more diversified source of demand for CNH bonds.

Exhibit 13: July 2026 Measures to Strengthen Hong Kong's Offshore RMB Bond Market

The initiatives focus on three priorities: expanding investor demand, improving market liquidity, and enhancing market infrastructure.

Measure	Key Details	Market Implication
Expand Southbound Bond Connect	Annual quota increased from RMB 500bn to RMB 800bn; repo financing introduced; product scope expanded.	Supports larger Mainland inflows into offshore RMB bonds and improves secondary-market liquidity.
Increase RMB Liquidity Support	RMB Business Facility expanded from RMB 200bn to RMB 500bn; longer tenors added.	Strengthens CNH funding conditions and supports market-making activities.
Develop Offshore RMB Yield Curve	Exploration of offshore RMB short-term debt issuance.	Improves benchmark pricing and facilitates broader bond issuance.
Enhance Hedging & Risk Management	Launch of 5-Year China Government Bond Futures in Hong Kong.	Provides institutional investors with duration-hedging tools, increasing market participation.
Improve Collateral Framework	Eligible Northbound Bond Connect bonds can be used as margin collateral.	Enhances capital efficiency and strengthens onshore-offshore market integration.
Promote RMB tion	Development of IDR-CNH transaction framework and measures to encourage RMB adoption.	Supports wider regional use of RMB in trade, financing, and investment activities.

Source: HKMA, PBoC, SFC

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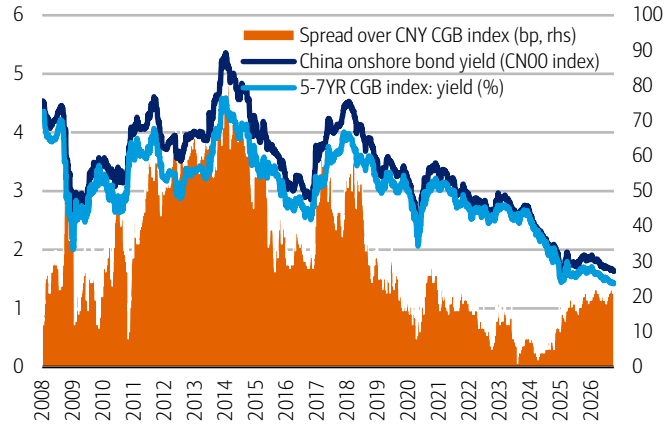
In addition to the Southbound Bond Connect expansion, according to a Bloomberg report (September 2026), citing people familiar with the matter, regulators are considering allowing the National Social Security Fund (NSSF) to invest in offshore RMB bond markets. Such a development could represent a meaningful new source of demand, particularly for high-quality, long-duration credits. At end-2025, the NSSF had RMB580bn invested overseas, equivalent to approximately 15% of its total assets of RMB3.8tn. Even a modest increase in offshore allocations could translate into significant incremental demand for CNH assets.

Third, the CNH market offers investors differentiated exposure relative to the onshore bond market. China's domestic bond market remains heavily concentrated in government, policy-bank and SOE issuers, resulting in low aggregate yields and limited sector diversification. By contrast, the CNH market provides access to a broader mix of issuers, including foreign financial institutions, multinational corporates, Hong Kong issuers and private-sector Chinese companies. This not only offers a yield premium over the onshore market but also provides exposure to a wider range of industries, business models and geographic risks.

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Exhibit 14: Weighted average yield of China onshore bond vs China government bond

The weighted average yield of China onshore CNY bond is 1.64% now, with only 10-20bps pick-up over CGBs (5-7YR)

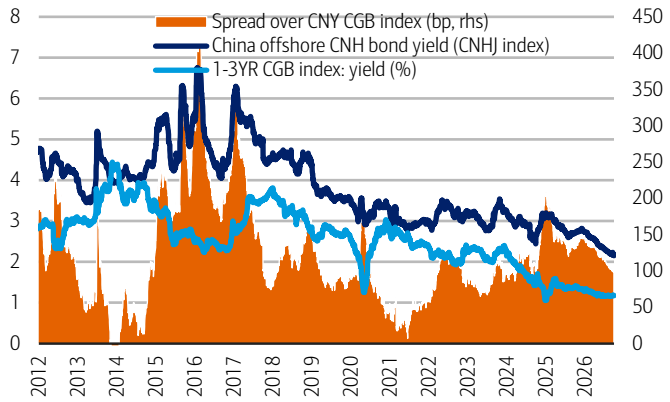


Source: ICE Data Indices, BofA Global Research

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Exhibit 15: Weighted average yield of China offshore CNH bond vs China government bond

The weighted average yield of China offshore CNH bond is now 2.15%, declining 60bp from end-2025; still offer 100bp pick-up over CGBs (1-3YR), though tightened 40bp from end-25



Source: ICE Data Indices, BofA Global Research

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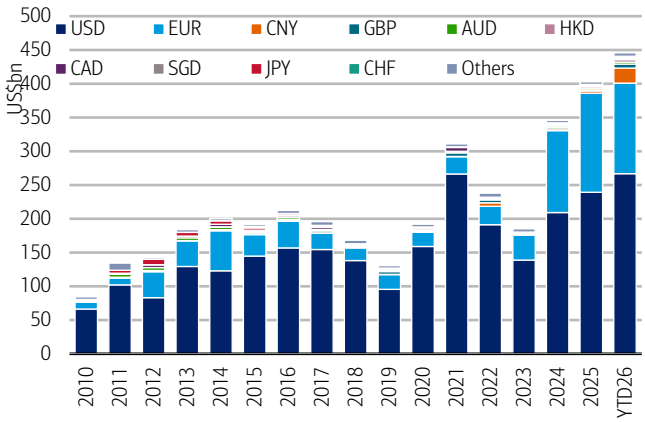
Taken together, these developments suggest that the recent growth of the CNH market is increasingly being driven by structural demand rather than cyclical funding dynamics. As offshore RMB liquidity expands and investor participation broadens, we see scope for the offshore Chinese capital pool to play an increasingly important role in supporting the long-term development of the CNH market.

CNH Emerges as a Strategic Funding Market alternative for US GSIBs

Year-to-date, U.S. GSIBs have issued approximately US$22bn equivalent of CNH bonds, compared with only US$2-3bn annually during 2023-25. CNH has now overtaken GBP to become the third-largest funding currency for U.S. GSIBs after USD and EUR. Against total issuance of approximately US$445bn, banks have raised US$267bn in USD, US$134bn in EUR and US$22bn in CNH, compared with just US$6bn in GBP.

Exhibit 16: US GSIB Bond issuance trend since 2010

USD and EUR are the major funding currency of US GSIBs

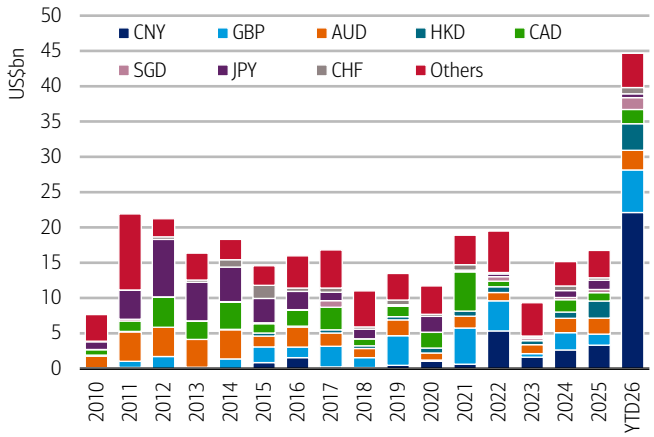


Source: Bloomberg, BofA Global Research

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Exhibit 17: US GSIB Bond issuance trend (ex USD & EUR) since 2010

CNH has become the third-largest funding currency for U.S. GSIBs after USD and EUR.



Source: Bloomberg, BofA Global Research

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The motivations for issuing CNH have also evolved. Early issuance was likely driven by a [illegible]n of business expansion in Greater China, growing RMB balance-sheet needs

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and attractive funding economics. Today, funding-cost advantages versus USD have largely disappeared after hedging. Yet issuance has accelerated markedly. This suggests to us that access to China's growing offshore capital pool, rather than funding cost advantage, has become the primary consideration.

The implications extend beyond the funding needs of individual banks. As repeat benchmark issuers, GSIBs play an important role in shaping market development. Their participation broadens the issuer base, improves sector diversification and increases the supply of high-quality investment-grade assets available to RMB investors. In turn, this supports market liquidity and enhances the attractiveness of the CNH market for both investors and future issuers.

The rapid increase in issuance over the past year therefore represents more than just a funding trend. It suggests that CNH is increasingly being incorporated into the strategic funding framework of global banks. Much as EUR became an integral component of GSIB funding programmes after the shift in relative funding economics post-2023, we believe CNH is now establishing itself as a permanent source of capital alongside USD and EUR. For the CNH market, this marks an important transition from a market serving primarily China-related borrowers to one that is becoming increasingly relevant to the global financial system.

CNH Funding for China’s New Economy

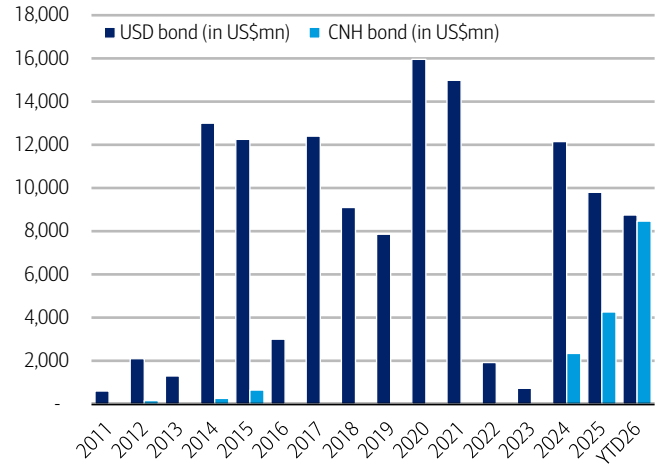
China's large internet platforms have historically been among the most important issuers in Asia's USD bond market. Since the early 2010s, companies such as Alibaba, Tencent, Baidu and JD.com have relied extensively on offshore USD funding to support acquisitions, capital expenditure, shareholder returns and general corporate purposes. However, in our view, the rapid development of the CNH market is beginning to reshape their funding mix. Over the past three years, CNH has evolved from a niche funding option into a meaningful alternative source of offshore capital, with issuance by Chinese technology companies rising sharply and approaching USD issuance levels in 2026.

CNH bond issuance by Chinese technology companies increased from RMB17bn in 2024 to RMB30bn in 2025, before accelerating to RMB57bn (US$8.5bn equivalent) in 2026. Over the same period, USD bond issuance declined from US$12bn in 2024 to US$9.8bn in 2025 and further to US$8.8bn year-to-date in 2026. As a result, CNH issuance is now broadly comparable to USD issuance for the sector, highlighting the growing importance of CNH as an offshore funding channel.

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Exhibit 18: Annual USD bond and CNH bond issuance by Chinese tech companies

Chinese tech companies started to issue CNH bond since 2024; YTD26 CNH issuance is similar with USD bond issuance

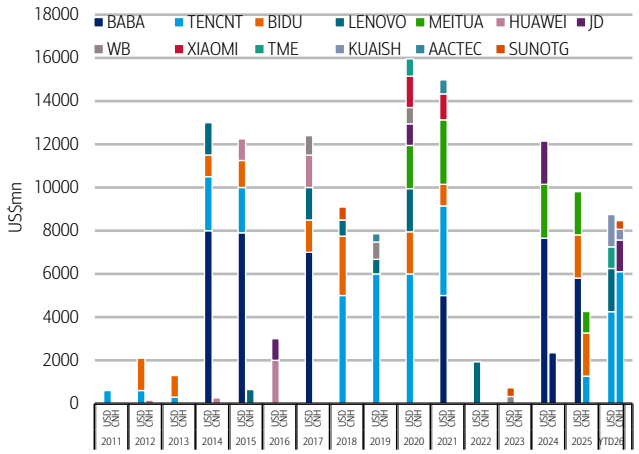


Source: Bloomberg, BofA Global Research

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Exhibit 19: Annual USD bond and CNH bond issuance by Chinese tech companies, breakdown by issuers

YTD26, Tencent issued 60% of USD&CNH bond from Chinese tech companies



Source: Bloomberg, BofA Global Research

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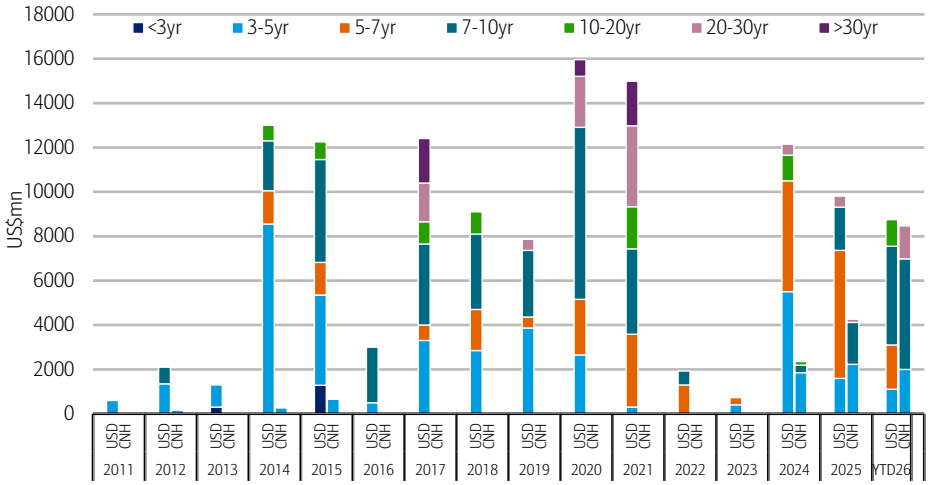
Several factors make CNH a natural funding currency for Chinese technology companies. Most generate the majority of their revenues and operating cash flow in RMB, making CNH liabilities a better match for their underlying cash flows than USD debt. At the same time, the VIE (Variable Interest Entity) structures adopted by some Chinese internet companies limit their direct access to the onshore bond market, making offshore markets an important source of debt funding. Some of these companies also have substantial offshore funding needs, including share repurchases, dividend payments, strategic investments and overseas acquisitions. CNH therefore provides a natural alternative to USD funding, allowing issuers to raise offshore capital while reducing the FX mismatch associated with USD liabilities.

The inclusion of Chinese insurers in Southbound Bond Connect in 2025 introduced a significant source of demand for long-dated RMB assets, helping to deepen the CNH market beyond its traditional short-to-medium tenor focus. As a result, more than 75% of CNH bonds issued by Chinese technology companies year-to-date have maturities exceeding seven years. The development of a longer-duration investor base is particularly important for technology issuers whose funding needs are increasingly linked to multi-year AI and infrastructure investments rather than short-term refinancing requirements.

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Exhibit 20: Annual USD bond and CNH bond issuance by Chinese tech companies, breakdown by issuance tenor

Chinese tech companies can issue CNH bond in long-tenor, like 10yr and 30yr



Source: Bloomberg, BofA Global Research

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Looking ahead, we expect AI-related investment to become the next major driver of funding demand. China's leading internet companies are entering an intensive capex cycle as they expand data-center capacity, acquire AI chips and secure computing resources. We estimate China's AI-related capex requirements at approximately US$1.5tn during 2026-30, of which roughly US$900bn will be undertaken by China's major internet platforms. (See report: Funding APAC's AI Revolution #2: Who will fund China's AI DC buildout capex? 16 October 2026) This represents a meaningful step-up from historical investment levels and is likely to drive a sustained increase in external funding needs despite strong operating cash-flow generation.

While these companies continue to generate substantial RMB cash flow, internal resources alone are unlikely to fully fund simultaneously rising AI investment, ongoing share buybacks and dividend distributions. As a result, we see scope for offshore debt funding to play an increasingly important role in capital allocation decisions. In our view, the recent increase in CNH issuance therefore reflects not only funding diversification but also the growing financing requirements associated with China's next investment cycle.

We would expect China's technology champions to remain active issuers in both USD and CNH markets. Given the scale of anticipated funding requirements, we think the two markets should be viewed as complementary rather than competing sources of capital. We would expect USD funding to remain important for offshore expenditures, including semiconductor purchases, overseas acquisitions and international compute leasing, while CNH provides access to a rapidly expanding pool of Chinese capital and liabilities that are more naturally aligned with RMB-denominated revenues and cash flows.

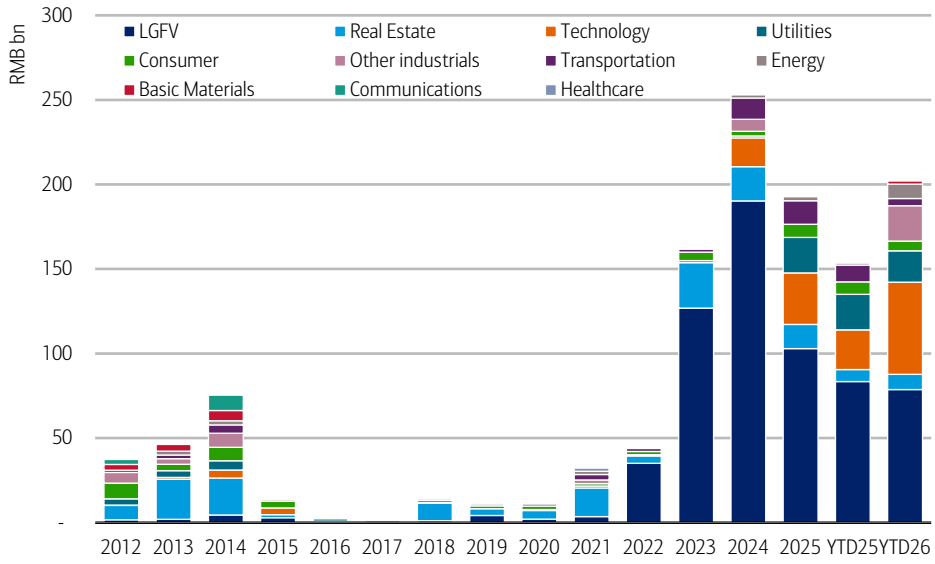
The beneficiaries of this trend, however, are likely to be concentrated among the sector's larger and higher-quality issuers. While AI investment will also drive significant funding needs among data-center operators, cloud infrastructure providers and other digital infrastructure companies, many of these issuers face greater capital intensity and weaker near-term cash-flow generation. Given the limited presence of dedicated high-yield investors in the CNH market, funding opportunities are likely to remain concentrated among investment-grade technology platforms and other strong credits. As a result, we expect China's leading internet companies to remain the primary technology issuers in the CNH market, reinforcing its role as a key funding channel for China's new economy.

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LGFVs: No Longer a Growth Driver

Local government financing vehicles (LGFVs) played a significant role in the recent expansion of the CNH bond market, particularly during 2022-24. Their participation was largely driven by tightening access to onshore funding channels, which prompted many LGFVs to seek alternative sources of capital offshore.

Exhibit 21: CNH non-financial corp bond issuance trend since 2012, in RMB bn
The CNH non-financial corp bond issuance was muted during 2015-20; China LGFV is the major driver since 2022; however, the share of China LGFV declined to 53% in 2025 and further to 40% in YTD26; meanwhile, more issuance came from tech, utility, industrial companies



Source: Bloomberg, BofA Global Research
Note: YTD26 as of Oct 20 2026

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CNH issuance by LGFVs first accelerated in 2022, reaching RMB35bn. Issuance then increased sharply to RMB126bn in 2023 and further to RMB190bn in 2024, accounting for 34% of total CNH bond issuance that year. During this period, LGFVs were one of the fastest-growing issuer groups in the market and contributed materially to the rapid expansion of overall CNH bond supply.

The growth proved temporary, however. As policymakers intensified efforts to reduce local government leverage and address hidden debt risks, regulatory scrutiny of offshore borrowing increased. Authorities gradually tightened supervision of LGFV offshore financing and restricted new issuance primarily to refinancing existing obligations rather than funding new investment or expansion projects. As a result, LGFV issuance declined to RMB102bn in 2025 and has fallen further to below RMB79bn year-to-date in 2026.

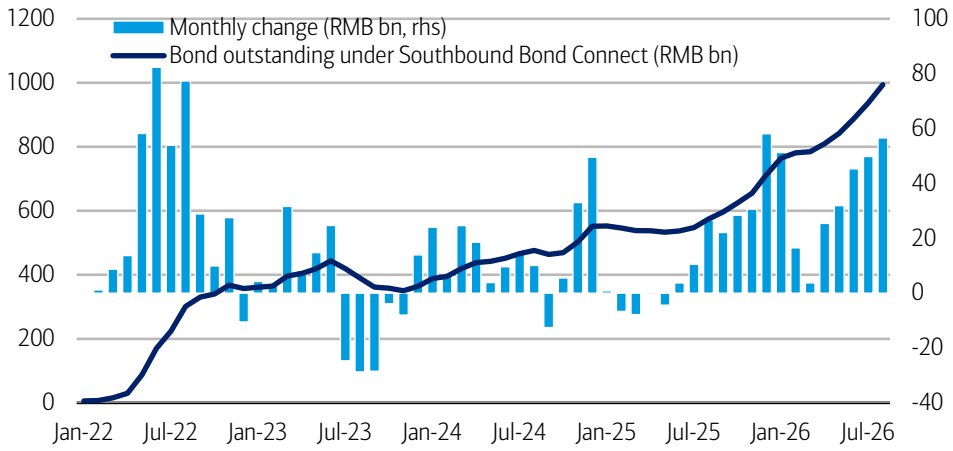
We would expect this trend to continue. The current policy direction remains focused on deleveraging and liability management rather than renewed credit expansion. In our view, LGFV issuance is likely to remain subject to strict regulatory oversight and largely limited to refinancing purposes. As a result, the sector is unlikely to be a major driver of future CNH market growth.

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Strong Demand Supports Continued Market Growth

The outlook for the CNH market ultimately depends on the balance between investor demand and the availability of investable assets. In our view, the demand side remains firmly supportive. Since the relaxation of Southbound Bond Connect in August 2025, bonds held through Shanghai Clearing House under the program have increased by approximately RMB460bn, highlighting the strong appetite among Mainland investors for offshore RMB credit. The attraction is straightforward: relative to the onshore bond market, CNH bonds offer both higher yields and exposure to a broader set of industries, business models and geographic risks.

Exhibit 22: Bond held by Shanghai Clearing House under the Southbound Bond Connect Program
As of end-Aug'26, bond outstanding held by SHCH under the Southbound Bond Connect Program reached RMB1.0tn, increasing RMB460bn post eligible investor expansion (Jul'25)



Source: Shanghai Clearing House, Bloomberg

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Importantly, the pace of inflows has not been constrained by demand, but by policy limits. The annual Southbound Bond Connect quota was almost fully utilized within a year after the investor base was expanded and subsequently increased from RMB500bn to RMB800bn recently. The speed at which capital has been deployed suggests to us that existing allocations remain insufficient to satisfy investor demand.

Assuming the annual quota remains unchanged at RMB800bn, the CNH market could still grow at a substantial pace. Relative to the current market size of RMB1.9tn, annual inflows of up to RMB800bn would imply potential growth equivalent to more than 40% of the existing market. While actual growth will likely depend on issuance conditions and investor behavior, the quota itself remains one of the most important determinants of the market's near-term growth trajectory.

We believe this demand backdrop should continue to encourage issuance. The growing offshore RMB investor base has seemingly already established CNH as a strategic funding channel for two important issuer groups: Chinese technology companies and global financial institutions. Chinese technology firms are increasingly using CNH to fund AI-related investment while better matching their predominantly RMB-denominated cash flows. At the same time, U.S. GSIBs have rapidly increased CNH issuance as they seek access to China's expanding capital pool.

As the market continues to deepen, we believe a broader set of high-quality issuers may consider accessing the market. In particular, investment-grade corporates, financial institutions, supranationals and sovereign issuers from outside China may view CNH as an increasingly attractive source of diversified funding. Similar to the evolution of the

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Samurai and Kangaroo markets, investor-base diversification rather than relative funding-costs could become the primary driver of future issuance.

The principal uncertainty for our growth outlook remains policy. Given the strong demand for offshore RMB assets, the Southbound Bond Connect quota is increasingly acting as a binding constraint on market growth. Any further increase in the quota, expansion of eligible investor groups, or inclusion of large institutional investors such as the National Social Security Fund could accelerate market growth materially. Conversely, if the quota remains unchanged for an extended period, growth is likely to become increasingly constrained by the amount of capital permitted to flow offshore rather than by investor demand.

Overall, we believe the CNH market is well positioned to continue its expansion. Strong structural demand, an increasingly diversified investor base and growing issuer adoption should support further market growth, even if the pace ultimately depends on future policy decisions regarding capital-channel access. In our view, the question is no longer whether the CNH market will continue to grow, but rather how quickly regulators will allow offshore RMB capital pools to expand.

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Research Analysts

Asia Pacific Credit Rsch Grp

Sirius Chan
Research Analyst
Merrill Lynch (Hong Kong)
sirius.chan@bofa.com

Xiang Gao, CFA
Research Analyst
Merrill Lynch (Singapore)
xiang.gao@bofa.com

Rachna Jain, CFA
Research Analyst
Merrill Lynch (Singapore)
rachna.jain2@bofa.com

Lefu Li, CFA
Research Analyst
Merrill Lynch (Hong Kong)
lefu.li@bofa.com

Joyce Liang
Research Analyst
Merrill Lynch (Singapore)
joyce.liang@bofa.com

Anders Lim
Research Analyst
Merrill Lynch (Singapore)
anguan.lim@bofa.com

Suyang Lu
Research Analyst
Merrill Lynch (Hong Kong)
suyang.lu@bofa.com

Di Miao, CFA
Research Analyst
Merrill Lynch (Hong Kong)
dmiao@bofa.com

Jing Peng
Research Analyst
Merrill Lynch (Hong Kong)
jing.peng2@bofa.com

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